Design Journal: Nintendo Switch 2

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Introduction

The Nintendo Switch 2 is a new console recently released by Nintendo. I chose it because I often use it in my daily life. Unlike a PC or a PlayStation 5, the Switch 2 is unique because it can play Nintendo's exclusive games and many of which are designed for family and group play. At the same time, Nintendo has also collaborated with many well-known IPs. Hence, its console features both large-scale single-player adventure games and relaxing multiplayer interactive games. This combination enables it to attract users of different types. Casual players can pick it up for short sessions, while core gamers can spend hours progressing through long games. Young children can also enjoy simple games, and during family or friend gatherings, everyone can play together cooperatively. Its portability also makes it very suitable for playing while commuting or out of home.

For this design journal, I will focus on three specific aspects of the Switch 2. These are its hardware form and portability, user interface and navigation, and game performance. To analyze these aspects, I will apply three design principles which are affordance, feedback, and usability goals. This will allow me to evaluate which parts of the design are effective and which could be improved

Hardware Form and Portability & Affordance

One of the outstanding design aspects of Switch 2 is its hardware appearance and portability. The console offers three different playing modes: handheld mode, desktop mode, and TV projection mode. These modes indicate how users could use the device without complex instructions. For instance, the detachable controller and the stand behind the screen are strong visual cues which are signifiers that directly indicate how the player can hold the device, set it up on the table, and play on the TV. This is what is referred to as affordance we discussed during the lecture. The shape of the object directly conveys its possible uses.

From my personal experience, the large screen of the Switch 2 provides a better gaming experience in handheld mode. However, the second generation is heavier compared to the first generation. Although it is still portable, it can be tiring to hold it for a long time. This also confirms what reading argues that the design always involves trade-offs and one has to decide which type of user needs to be prioritized. The larger screen improves the graphic quality and visibility of the game but sacrifices some comfort for long-term carrying. In contrast, the PlayStation 5 has no portability affordance at all as its large fixed shape indicates that it can only be used at home. This comparison also highlights the uniqueness of the Switch series. Portability has become the best reflected part of the user experience.

Overall, the hardware design of Switch 2 effectively embodies affordance and allows users to understand how to use it at a glance. However, it also indicates that merely having

affordance is not enough for perfection because designers still need to balance the portability and user experience.

User Interface and Navigation & Feedback

One of the strongest aspects of the Switch 2 is its user interface and navigation system. The menus are designed with simple icons such as a gear for settings or a shopping bag for the online store. These clear visual symbols make it easy for users to understand where to go and every interaction is supported with immediate feedback. For example, when a user clicks on an icon, the screen will highlight the option and be accompanied by a slight sound effect. According to lectures, feedback is very important for design because it can tell users whether the system has received the operation and help avoid confusion. The consistency of Switch 2 in terms of highlighting and sound feedback enables players to confirm whether their commands have been executed.

From my own experience, the Nintendo eShop on the Switch 2 also provides structured feedback through its organization. The store divides games into clear categories such as Great Deals, Best Sellers, Coming Soon, and so on. This makes navigation smoother. This matches what the reading argues that good design should emphasize clarity and reduce cognitive load. When users can quickly find the content they need, they will feel less frustrated and gain more satisfaction. Compared with some complex digital stores, the interface of Switch 2 uses a simple structure and immediate response to make it easier for users to understand and maintain the operation.

In summary, the interface of Switch 2 achieves effective feedback through the organization of visuals and sounds. It keeps users always clear about what the system is doing, thereby enhancing usability.

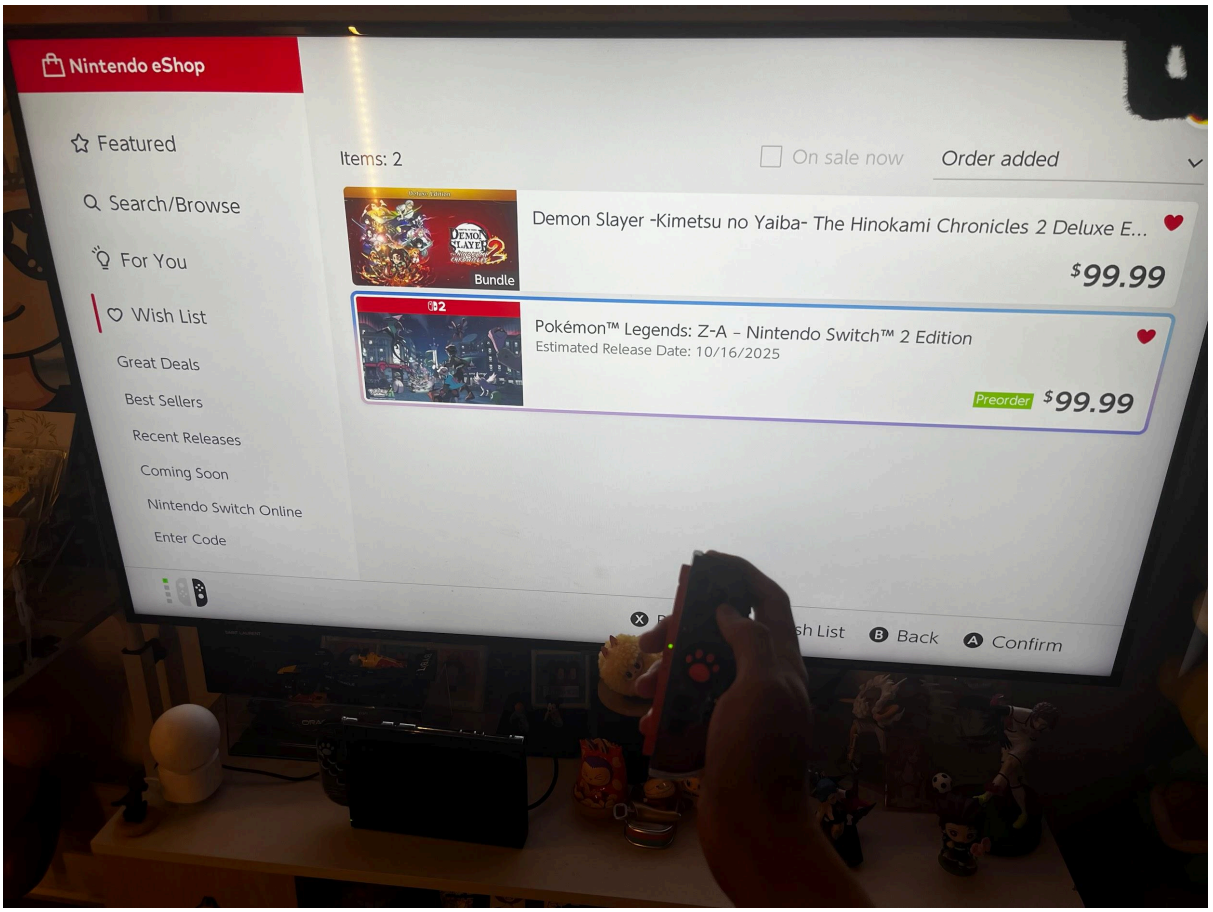
Game Performance & Usability Goals

Another important aspect of the Switch 2 is its game performance that can be evaluated through usability goals. Compared to the first generation, the Switch 2 has made a major improvement in graphics quality and system responsiveness. Faster game loading and clearer graphics reflect the effectiveness and efficiency in usability. For players, this means that more game graphic details will be displayed on the screen and the gaming process will be smoother. However, this improvement also brings about trade-offs. Stronger performance has led to a decline in its battery life. This is an argument in reading that design always needs to balance among conflicting goals and improving performance or increasing complexity often brings new problems.

From my perspective, the improvement in the graphic quality of Switch 2 is quite obvious. Especially for some upgraded and newly released games, they can be run more smoothly and have higher resolutions. But at the same time, I also noticed that some games require the purchase of additional upgrade packs which is a burden for users. This weakens the satisfaction in usability because not all players think it's reasonable to pay again such as me. Compared with PlayStation 5, this gap is more intuitive. The PS5 offers better performance but it can only be used fixedly at home. The Switch 2 sacrificed its performance

in order to maintain portability. This comparison indicates that usability goals are not absolute but rather depend on the users and usage scenarios that designers prioritize.

Together, the Switch 2 has achieved many usability goals in terms of speed, response and visual experience. However, its reduced battery life and additional costs also remind us that usability is not only about technical performance but also about users' long-term satisfaction.



Conclusion

In conclusion, the Nintendo Switch 2 illustrates both the strengths and the challenges of modern game console design. Its hardware form and portability show strong affordance by making the three modes of play obvious through their physical design. Its user interface and navigation reflect effective feedback. This reduces confusion and supports interaction with the system through simple icons, highlights and sound effects. Moreover, its game performance demonstrates the key usability goals. There has been an improvement in graphic quality and frame rate but at the cost of reduced battery life and additional upgrade costs. Together, the Switch 2 is an outstanding product in overall design. However, they are also subject to various trade-offs and different user groups will feel different impacts.

The Switch 2 is successful because it combines portability, accessibility, and enjoyment in ways that other consoles like the PlayStation 5 cannot. At the same time, it also reminded me of a core point from the lectures and reading. Good design is never

perfect. It is the result of constantly weighing priorities and finally meeting the real needs of users.

Reference

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Lecture slides

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